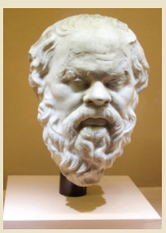
other. This war is known as the Peloponnesian War. Athens, despite hostility and disturbance from Sparta, became a noble city with magnificent buildings. There were great artists and great thinkers. Historians therefore call this the **Age of Pericles**.


Pericles

The Athenian government, after Pericles, did not like Socrates' way of finding truth. In a trial, Socrates was accused of refusing to accept the gods recognized by the State and corrupting the youth. The jury found Socrates guilty and sentenced him to die by drinking hemlock (a poison).


Socrates

5. 2 Rome: The Hellenistic World

Beginnings of Hellenistic Civilisation

The Greek city-states did not have an elaborate bureaucracy. They were therefore able to show a greater dynamism. Under Alexander the Great, the Greeks were able to establish a kingdom in Macedonia. This kingdom succeeded in annexing two historic empires of Egypt and the Middle East. But the entire period of Alexander's reign was spent on wars.

Cultural development that took place rapidly after Alexander's death 323 BC (BCE) is called **Hellenistic civilisation**.

The Greek school of Science, Mathematics and Philosophy reached its peak in the Greek-Egyptian city of Alexandria. **Euclid** who formulated the basic theorems of geometry, **Eratosthenes** who accurately calculated the diameter of the earth, and **Hipparchus**, the founder of trigonometry were all products of this age. **Ptolemy** built on Hipparchus's ideas and later developed a model of motion of the planets and stars.

Roman Republic

In the beginning Rome was a society of agriculturists, organized through lineages. Out of this developed a hereditary ruling class. Roman people were divided into two classes: Patricians, rich landlords, and Plebeians, a common citizens.

Rome was strategically located in the crisscrossing trade routes cutting north–south and east–west. Taxes on passing traders added to the revenue derived from agriculture. By the late 6th century BC (BCE), Rome developed into a prosperous town.

Class War between Patricians and Plebeians

Prisoners of war were enslaved in Rome. Thus Rome produced a new labour force for the rich to exploit. Big landholders bought slaves cheaply and used them to cultivate their estates. The slave population grew and by the 1st century BC (BCE) there were two million slaves, when the total strength of free population was 3.25 million. Slave labour led to the impoverishment of free labour. Many poor peasants had to abandon their children who also ended up in the slave markets. The conflict between Plebeians and Patricians became bloodier.

A major source of revenue to the Roman state was slave trade. The island of Delos became a great slave market.

Tiberius Gracchus and Garius do Gracchus, though Patricians, voiced their opinion in favour of the poor peasants. As the peasants supported their programme, the Senators, shocked by this development, murdered both of them. The martyrdom of the Gracchus brothers played a decisive role in the transformation of the Roman Republic into the Roman Empire.

9th_History_Unit_5_EM.indd 68 08-04-2022 10:43:20